that we could see the beginnings of the first conflicts between the indigenous population of Western Europe and non-European immigrants.[110] By then, however, all these countries began to look for legal and other ways to curb the arrival of (no longer economically necessary) migrant workers or even encouraged them to return home. Welcome reasons for this were also the developments in the European Union and the principle of free movement of workers within it, which enabled workers from the Union's Mediterranean countries to work in the West and the North. At the time, though, the number of non-European workers (and their family members whose arrival was explicitly or tacitly allowed by the countries mentioned) had already grown so much that they had become a social problem, even if countries such as Germany have long insisted that they are just guest workers and not real immigrants.

Aware of the tragic experience of Nazism (and also because of their bad consciences about it), post-war European governments avoided racist undertones in their efforts to curb non-European immigration. They based their new policy on the risk to public order and peace, and only later on the incompatibility of cultures – Chin speaks of 'cultural nationalism'[111] adopted by both left and right, partly due to movements such as Le Pen's party in France. It was France that went through long and wide public debates in the 1980s, trying to redefine what it means to be French; most of these discussions agreed on the need for a common language, culture, civic values and integration, which must not weaken the national identity – that is, by emphasising the integration of immigrants but also their assimilation. In the UK and Germany, a little more room was left for cultural pluralism.

According to Chin, a decisive milestone in the approach to immigrant policy in Western Europe came with the publication of *The Satanic Verses* by Salman Rushdie in 1988. In Britain, Muslims availed themselves of democratic means to prevent the publication of this book, which, in their view, severely offended their religious sentiments. However, when the Iranian ayatollah became involved in this European story with a deadly fatwa against Rushdie, the perception in British (and other Western societies) changed: the opposition to the book became a problem of a supposedly monolithic, unchanging world Muslim community incapable of accepting the European principle of freedom of speech and not fully prepared to give up violence. (Rushdie was actually stabbed and severely